

BENROBERTSQUEENSLANDRAIL

The city of Gladstone in Queensland is right at the start of the Great Barrier Reef. I caught the train from there to Brisbane's Roma Street Station, a 650km trip and chatted with one of Queensland Rail's regional managers, Ben Roberts. Travel Radio Australia, we're at Roma Street Station in Brisbane and I'm here with Ben Roberts from Queensland Rail.

And Ben, welcome to the program. Thank you for having me, Geoff. It's great to have a chat about some trains.

Now we're on the platform here. I've just arrived on a fabulous trip from Gladstone. Six hour trip, around 650km trip.

Tell us about this train here that's just about to go out. It's one of the most iconic trains in Queensland. Yeah, so this is one of our long distance trains, the Spirit of Queensland.

So that's the one that travels from Brisbane all the way up to Cairns, stopping at all the stations in between. But yeah, running for about 20 years. It's about a 25 hour journey from here to Cairns.

So yeah, it departs 3.45pm and we'll arrive approximately 5pm into Cairns. And it's a sleeper train, right? Not a sleeper, it's a rail bed. So this is one where we have our rail bed class and our economy class.

So the rail bed space has reclinable beds that sit up and then recline flat for the evening. In that space you get all your meals and everything's brought to your seat. So you have a lovely little space to enjoy the trip and we can have some great food and refreshment along the way.

Well, that's just like a first class flight really, isn't it? The same sort of experience. Yeah, it's similar to that space with that rail bed. But yeah, nice and flat and it allows you to connect those communities and enjoy that space while you're travelling up to Cairns.

And now for the tourists coming from overseas, Roma Street is really the hub, isn't it, for everything, for all the services going to North Queensland? Yeah, the majority. So out of Brisbane we have, I guess, five of the seven main services that we do across the network. So yeah, we have all our trains come up to Roma Street and depart from here.

So that's our Spirit of Queensland, the electric tilt trains for Bundaberg and Rockhampton, which you just came in on. Then we have the Westlander service which heads out to Charlevoix. And then we have the Spirit of the Outback service which heads out to Longreach.

So the only ones that don't go from here are our Cran-to-Sceney Grail routes and our Gulflander routes, which are up in far North Queensland. People can catch it here to go down to the Gold Coast and up to the Sunshine Coast too. Yeah, correct.

So you join all your city train services out of Brisbane. So yeah, as you said, if you need to go down the Gold Coast out to Moreton Bay, to Ipswich, and then up North up to sort of Gympie and Nambour, those sort of stations for the city train. Yeah, so people can, you know, really get around Queensland very easily with this service.

And I found the trip from Gladstone extremely relaxing. You have Wi-Fi on board, you've got a galley on board, they come around with the food carts. Great service.

Yeah, that's what we sort of aim for. So we're very mindful of connecting those communities throughout Queensland and the rail network, which is one of the biggest in Australia and it's still existing, so we really want to take care of what we do and getting those services around the state. And also that emphasis on, yeah, we're trying to provide that world-class service offering for your customers to enjoy while you're travelling, you know, putting your feet up and relaxing on the railway.

And while we're here, tell us about some of the other services you have, apart from the ones we've already mentioned. So another great one's out of Brisbane, we have the Spirit of the Outback, which is one of our, I guess, iconic ones, and one with our sleeper cabins. So that's one of our, I guess, that romantic vision that people have of the railway, with a restaurant cart, dining cart, sleeper cabin, and that sort of space.

But another 25-hour journey from here to Longreach, and a great way for our team to really give that service and look after people and people who enjoy their holiday. Some other ones we do have as part of the group, but maybe not out of Brisbane, is our Carrander Scenic Rail, so another amazing tourist offering up in Cairns. It goes up the Carrander Ranges, up to Carrander, and a lovely little scenic route past Barron Falls, and seeing lots of sights out there.

So, I guess, a balance between tourism services and those long-distance services, so not just the tourism offering, but getting people from A to B as well. You do have discount rates for 65-plus and people over 60. Tell us a bit about that.

Yeah, so we have a number of different offerings, so yeah, concession prices and pension pricing. So the best way, if you go into queenslandrailtravel.com.au, is just to see their range of fares. So I think one-way tickets start from \$30, and as you said, very different concession pricing, but we also do two-for-one specials at different times of the year for different services and things like that.

So if you go to that website, queenslandrailtravel.com.au, it just outlines all those different prices and different concessions that you can get. Yeah, \$59 from all the way from Gladstone for a six-hour train ride is incredible value. And the thing is that if you look at the flights, it's often the same.

When you say six hours, it sounds like a long time, but by the time you get to the airport, it can be equivalent. Yeah, correct. And I guess that's, yeah, especially in those Bundaberg and

Rockhampton runs, you know, we try to keep it on time and on its way.

But yeah, it just gives you another option where you can sit back, relax. It also allows for, you know, for a number of people coming down to use hospitals and things in Brisbane, it allows those services that people can't fly. So it's a great alternative option.

Sometimes you think you need the time, but all the other times, as you said, it can provide that, you know, you're up at six o'clock on the train, you're in here by three o'clock. Oh yeah, the time just flies by and you can just get out your computer and do some work and chat or follow your social media on board. It's very, very relaxing.

And I found that the staff are great too, because they have a great attitude on Queensland Rail. You must be very proud of them. Yeah, as always, you know, the staff are the ones that deliver the package.

So a lot of the team members are long-serving and as we get new people through, we love to indoctrinate them into that world-class service offering that we want to give out. And a lot of the time spent, you know, contact hours with them, ensuring that they have the tools for their job. And if you want to splash out, tell us about the first class services.

They really, you get pampered. We sort of said, so we have that rail bed offering on the Spirit of the Queensland. So that's all meals are served to seat.

You can see the catering guys here now, but they're just provisioning the train, but that's our, so we have an individual catering unit that develops all the menus and stuff out of Brisbane and then delivers that stuff on board. So in the Spirit of the in those spaces and ensure that their meals are getting delivered on time. On the Spirit of the Outback, yeah, that's, as I said, a lovely one.

We have an on-board chef and an on-board tucker box restaurant. And that's the one where you have a lovely sleeper cabin, have your own space to, you know, look out the window and enjoy your train ride out to Longreach. But then you also come meal time, you're heading into the tucker box restaurant and enjoying those, that, you know, restaurant service and high level quality food offering, as well as the Shearer's rest lounge car where you can stop and have a drink and speak to your other fellow travellers.

Yeah, that sounds great. You can sit there and look on through the picture windows of Outback Queensland rolling by and the views are quite spectacular, especially when you have interesting weather combinations. Yeah, as you said, at the moment, a lot of rain out there this year, so it's lovely and green across the Drummond Ranges and as you head out to Longreach.

So yeah, I mean, that's the beauty of that rail travel is you get that first encounter, you can, you're not worried about driving the car, you're sitting back and you're relaxing, you can take in the scenery and you're a bit closer to the action as opposed to a plane where you're up in the air. But

yeah, those services where, you know, it really gives you the ability in that space to not to worry about where your next meal is coming from, you can get all, you're all looked after and all that, it's all organised for you. Ben Roberts from Queensland Rail.

How can people find out more online about your services? Yeah, as we said before, like the best way to book and find the information out is to head to queenslandrailtravel.com.au and it outlines, it has some great interactive tours, there's virtual tours of all our services, so you can actually jump on board, have a look at the trains, familiarise yourself with the spaces and see how it all sort of comes together. As we said before, it just outlines all those lovely sort of different discounts and ticket prices and specials that we do throughout the year. It'll give you updated menu information, all that sort of stuff as well, so yeah, a great little tool to jump on board, have a look and then you can go through bookings from there.

Great, Ben Roberts, thanks very much for being part of the program. No problem at all, thanks for having me.